

Distribution Centre Manager

FF15 Logistics, transport and supply chain · ISCO-08 1324 · CBS 0532 Managers logistiek · seniority lead · Also known as: DC manager, Site director logistics

Leads the full operation of a distribution centre, from staffing and safety to investment and client relationships.

The distribution centre manager holds overall responsibility for a site with often hundreds of employees and multiple shifts. The distinction from a warehouse manager lies in the broader responsibility for the whole site including investment and external client relations. Selection often fails on candidates with a strong operational track record who lack enough experience managing the commercial relationship with clients.

Key figures for this profile

25 skills · 6 competencies to measure · 4 knockout skills · centre of gravity: Professional knowledge domains 25%, Leadership and organising 15%, Execution, craft, safety and sustainability 13%

1 Competencies to measure

These are the behavioural and ability constructs in this profile. Each one shows which hrmforce questionnaire measures it.

Competencies to measure	Target level	hrmforce instrument	Assessment method	Behavioural anchor at target level
Directing and steering people Competency (50-framework): Aansturen Knockout	■■■■■N5	Big Fifty, Competency Check, 360 Feedback	Assessment center	Designs the management line for the whole organisation, addresses managers on their style and defines what good steering means here.

Competencies to measure	Target level	hrmforce instrument	Assessment method	Behavioural anchor at target level
Safety awareness Competency (50-framework): Discipline Knockout	 N4	Big Fifty, Competency Check	Situational Judgement Test	Recognises unsafe situations in own process, intervenes and addresses colleagues without bringing the work to a halt.
Accuracy and attention to detail Competency (50-framework): Nauwkeurigheid Knockout	 N4	Big Fifty, 360 Feedback	Persoonlijkheidsvragenlijst	Builds check moments into the own process, keeps track of errors and prevents repetition by adjusting the method.
Discipline and keeping commitments Competency (50-framework): Discipline	 N4	Big Fifty, 15PF, 360 Feedback	Persoonlijkheidsvragenlijst	Commits only to what is feasible, tracks own commitments and informs those involved as soon as a deadline comes under pressure.
Managing workload pressure Competency (50-framework): Stressbestendigheid	 N4	Big Fifty, Competency Check, Pulse Survey	Structureerd interview	Cuts or shifts tasks independently when busy on the basis of importance, records this and discusses consequences with clients.
Sustaining pace in repetitive work Competency (50-framework): Discipline	 N4	Big Fifty, Werkproef	Werkproef	Sustains the pace for a full shift, builds in own rhythm and short recovery moments and stays within the quality standard.

2 Full skill profile

Every skill in this profile, sorted by weight. The behavioural anchor under each skill belongs to the target level.

T	Skill	Target level	Weight	Knockout	Assessment method	hrmforce instrument
G	Directing and steering people Designs the management line for the whole organisation, addresses managers on their style and defines what good steering means here.	 N5	5	yes	Assessment center	Big Fifty, Competency Check, 360 Feedback
G	Safety awareness Recognises unsafe situations in own process, intervenes and addresses colleagues without bringing the work to a halt.	 N4	5	yes	Situational Judgement Test	Big Fifty, Competency Check
V	Stakeholder management Maintains a network reaching governance and political bodies, connects parties with differing interests and safeguards the position of the organisation.	 N5	4	no	Assessment center	Competency Check, 360 Feedback

T	Skill	Target level	Weight	Knockout	Assessment method	hrmforce instrument
V	Change management Leads organisation wide change programmes, aligns with works council and supervisors and sets the change approach of the organisation.	 N5	4	no	Assessment center	Competency Check, 360 Feedback
V	Business case and investment analysis Sets the calculation rules and threshold values for investments and weighs the entire investment portfolio of the organisation.	 N5	4	no	Werkproef	Werkproef, Kennistoets (klantspecifiek)
G	Accuracy and attention to detail Builds check moments into the own process, keeps track of errors and prevents repetition by adjusting the method.	 N4	4	yes	Persoonlijkheidsvragenlijst	Big Fifty, 360 Feedback

T	Skill	Target level	Weight	Knockout	Assessment method	hrmforce instrument
V	aligning and coordinating Organises consultation between the parties in a shared process, records agreements and actively tracks whether these are met.	 N4	4	no	Assessment center	Competency Check, 360 Feedback
V	Planning and organising Plans the work of the team for several weeks, distributes tasks and reshuffles on disruptions without missing deadlines.	 N4	4	no	Werkproef	Competency Check, 360 Feedback, Werkproef
G	Discipline and keeping commitments Commits only to what is feasible, tracks own commitments and informs those involved as soon as a deadline comes under pressure.	 N4	4	no	Persoonlijkheidsvragenlijst	Big Fifty, 15PF, 360 Feedback

T	Skill	Target level	Weight	Knockout	Assessment method	hrmforce instrument
V	Logistics planning Independently replans routes and capacity when resources fail, weighs cost against lead time and informs customer and carrier.	 N4	4	no	Werkproef	Werkproef, Kennistoets (klantspecifiek)
V	Operational inventory management Independently sets order levels for a product group, analyses stock differences and removes the cause in the process.	 N4	4	no	Werkproef	Werkproef, Kennistoets (klantspecifiek)
V	Executing transport and distribution Independently drives a multi drop route, keeps track of driving times and resolves problems at the customer on the spot.	 N4	4	no	Certificaat/diploma	Kennistoets (klantspecifiek), Werkproef

T	Skill	Target level	Weight	Knockout	Assessment method	hrmforce instrument
T	Using warehouse management systems Independently resolves differences between system stock and location and adjusts settings within own authority.	 N4	4	yes	Werkproef	Werkproef, Kennistoets (klantspecifiek)
V	Load securing and transport safety Independently determines the securing method for an unusual load, calculates the required lashing force and refuses unsafe transport.	 N4	4	no	Praktijkobservatie	Werkproef, Kennistoets (klantspecifiek)
V	Prioritising and weighing options Chooses what is left undone when the planning is full, justifies this by importance and urgency and aligns it with those involved.	 N4	3	no	Werkproef	Competency Check, Werkproef

T	Skill	Target level	Weight	Knockout	Assessment method	hrmforce instrument
V	Time management and prioritising Ranks own work by urgency and importance, builds in buffer time and explains to others why an item will arrive later.	 N4	3	no	Werkproef	Competency Check, 360 Feedback
G	Managing workload pressure Cuts or shifts tasks independently when busy on the basis of importance, records this and discusses consequences with clients.	 N4	3	no	Structureerd interview	Big Fifty, Competency Check, Pulse Survey
V	Working with digital devices and applications Selects the appropriate device and application for each task and fixes common disruptions without support from others.	 N4	3	no	Werkproef	Kennistoets (klantspecifiek), Werkproef

T	Skill	Target level	Weight	Knockout	Assessment method	hrmforce instrument
V	Operating machines Operates several machines independently, adjusts operating values to product condition and keeps output within the standard.	 N4	3	no	Werkproef	Werkproef, Kennistoets (klantspecifiek)
G	Sustaining pace in repetitive work Sustains the pace for a full shift, builds in own rhythm and short recovery moments and stays within the quality standard.	 N4	3	no	Werkproef	Big Fifty, Werkproef
V	Clear oral expression Builds an unprepared spoken explanation into core point, background and next step, and adapts pace to the listener.	 N3	2	no	Assessment center	Communicatiestijlen, Competency Check

T	Skill	Target level	Weight	Knockout	Assessment method	hrmforce instrument
V	Retaining and applying knowledge Knows the rules of the own field by heart and applies them without reference material in varying situations.	 N3	2	no	Kennistoets	Ability Scan, Kennistoets (klantspecifiek)
T	Spreadsheets and worksheets Builds a worksheet with linked formulas and pivot tables, checks for errors and explains the calculation logic to colleagues.	 N3	2	no	Werkproef	Kennistoets (klantspecifiek), Werkproef
V	Managing service levels and performance indicators Draws up indicators and standards for a service, reports per period and carries out improvement actions on deviation.	 N3	2	no	Werkproef	Werkproef, Competency Check

T	Skill	Target level	Weight	Knockout	Assessment method	hrmforce instrument
K	Customs and international trade documentation Independently determines commodity code and procedure for a shipment, files the declaration and answers questions from customs.	 N3	1	no	Kennistoets	Kennistoets (klantspecifiek)

3 Levels per seniority

The same profile with the job family seniority adjustment applied. Target levels are clamped to 1 to 5.

Skill	senior	lead
Directing and steering people	N5	N5
Safety awareness	N4	N4
Stakeholder management	N5	N5
Change management	N5	N5
Business case and investment analysis	N5	N5
Accuracy and attention to detail	N4	N4
aligning and coordinating	N4	N4
Planning and organising	N4	N4
Discipline and keeping commitments	N4	N4
Logistics planning	N4	N4
Operational inventory management	N4	N4
Executing transport and distribution	N4	N4
Using warehouse management systems	N4	N4
Load securing and transport safety	N4	N4
Prioritising and weighing options	N4	N4
Time management and prioritising	N4	N4
Managing workload pressure	N4	N4
Working with digital devices and applications	N4	N4
Operating machines	N4	N4
Sustaining pace in repetitive work	N4	N4
Clear oral expression	N3	N3
Retaining and applying knowledge	N3	N3
Spreadsheets and worksheets	N3	N3
Managing service levels and performance indicators	N3	N3
Customs and international trade documentation	N3	N3

4 The proficiency scale

Level	Label	Autonomy	Complexity	Scope	Depth of knowledge
N1	Guided	works under supervision and follows instruction	routine, one variable at a time	own task	basic understanding of terminology
N2	Applying	works independently within set frameworks	familiar situations with limited variation	own role	working knowledge, applies standard approach
N3	Proficient	sets own approach and seeks input proactively	several variables, some ambiguity	own team or process	thorough knowledge, weighs alternatives
N4	Advanced	directs others and decides on the approach	complex, with conflicting interests	several teams or a department	in-depth knowledge, advises others
N5	Leading	sets the standard and the policy	strategic, under high uncertainty	organisation, value chain or profession	authority, advances the profession

5 Behavioural anchors per skill

Anchors sit at N1, N3 and N5. N2 and N4 are deliberately not anchored: raters interpolate between them, following the O*NET convention.

Skill	N1	N3	N5
Directing and steering people Making clear to employees what is expected, giving assignments, setting boundaries and intervening when work or behaviour deviates from what was agreed.	Gives a colleague a concrete assignment with expected result and timing and checks whether the assignment is understood.	Sets expectations and boundaries per team member, addresses deviating behaviour directly and records agreements in writing.	Designs the management line for the whole organisation, addresses managers on their style and defines what good steering means here.
Safety awareness Continuously watches for unsafe situations and actions at work, addresses others about them and chooses the safe working method even under time pressure.	Follows the safety rules of the workplace and checks back when in doubt about an operation.	Recognises unsafe situations in own process, intervenes and addresses colleagues without bringing the work to a halt.	Sets the safety standard for the organisation, makes safety discussable at every level and steers behaviour and culture.

Skill	N1	N3	N5
Stakeholder management Mapping who has an interest in an initiative and maintaining contact with those parties so that decisions keep their support.	Maintains a list of those involved and informs them about progress according to the agreed rhythm.	Assesses influence and interest per party, chooses a fitting form of contact and discusses conflicting wishes before a decision is taken.	Maintains a network reaching governance and political bodies, connects parties with differing interests and safeguards the position of the organisation.
Change management Planning and guiding change by involving stakeholders, phasing steps, influencing behaviour and tracking the results the change is meant to deliver.	Adapts own way of working to an announced change and asks for explanation when steps are unclear.	Makes a change approach for the team with those involved, chooses interventions per group and follows the implementation.	Leads organisation wide change programmes, aligns with works council and supervisors and sets the change approach of the organisation.
Business case and investment analysis Substantiates a proposal with costs, benefits, assumptions and risks and calculates payback period and return for the decision makers.	Fills a standard business case template with supplied figures and names which data are still missing.	Builds an own business case with scenarios, makes the assumptions explicit and defends the outcome in the meeting.	Sets the calculation rules and threshold values for investments and weighs the entire investment portfolio of the organisation.
Accuracy and attention to detail Works carefully, checks own work for errors and keeps to agreements about completeness and correctness of data.	Goes through the own work with a checklist and repairs errors found before the work is passed on.	Builds check moments into the own process, keeps track of errors and prevents repetition by adjusting the method.	Sets the standards for completeness and correctness, has samples checked and addresses teams on structural sloppiness.
aligning and coordinating Aligning the activities of different people and groups in timing, sequence and content so that duplicated work and delays are prevented.	Aligns own activities with one direct colleague and confirms who picks up which task and when.	Organises consultation between the parties in a shared process, records agreements and actively tracks whether these are met.	Sets up the coordination structure between departments or chain partners and decides which meetings, roles and information flows the organisation uses as standard.
Planning and organising Placing activities, people and resources in time, setting priorities and arranging dependencies so that agreed results are delivered on schedule.	Makes a daily or weekly schedule for own tasks and sticks to the agreed order and times.	Plans the work of the team for several weeks, distributes tasks and reshuffles on disruptions without missing deadlines.	Sets the planning system for the organisation, links annual plan, capacity and budget and decides on conflicting claims.

Skill	N1	N3	N5
Discipline and keeping commitments Sticks to agreements, procedures and commitments even without supervision, and reports in good time when a commitment turns out to be unachievable.	Arrives at the agreed time with the agreed work and reports any delay to the supervisor.	Commits only to what is feasible, tracks own commitments and informs those involved as soon as a deadline comes under pressure.	Anchors the standard for reliable follow through in working agreements and addresses anyone at any level who lets that standard slip.
Logistics planning Plans goods flows, capacity and routes so that lead time, cost and availability stay balanced, and adjusts the plan when disruption occurs.	Completes the daily plan according to the standard schedule and reports availability bottlenecks to the planner.	Independently replans routes and capacity when resources fail, weighs cost against lead time and informs customer and carrier.	Designs the organisation's logistics network and planning principles and holds chain partners to performance agreements.
Operational inventory management Tracks stock levels, order moments and locations, carries out counts and explains differences between system stock and actual stock.	Counts stock under supervision according to the counting instruction and records the result in the system.	Independently sets order levels for a product group, analyses stock differences and removes the cause in the process.	Sets the inventory policy, defines standards for turnover and service level and tests execution against them.
Executing transport and distribution Transports and delivers goods according to route and driving time rules, checks freight documents and resolves deviations when loading and unloading.	Drives a fixed route under guidance, checks the consignment note and reports deviations on delivery.	Independently drives a multi drop route, keeps track of driving times and resolves problems at the customer on the spot.	Sets the execution standards for transport, reviews compliance with driving times and instructs drivers on new rules.
Using warehouse management systems Uses a warehouse management system for receipt, storage, order picking and shipping and resolves differences between system and shop floor.	Registers receipts and order lines in the system according to the work instruction and reports error messages to the team leader.	Independently resolves differences between system stock and location and adjusts settings within own authority.	Determines the configuration of the warehouse system, sets rules for its use and leads the introduction of new functionality.

Skill	N1	N3	N5
Load securing and transport safety Secures loads according to weight, centre of gravity and regulations and works safely when loading, unloading and carrying dangerous goods.	Secures a load under supervision with the prescribed equipment and checks before departure that the lashing straps are tensioned.	Independently determines the securing method for an unusual load, calculates the required lashing force and refuses unsafe transport.	Draws up the company's load safety instructions, analyses incidents and tests compliance among drivers and loading crews.
Prioritising and weighing options Orders tasks and options by importance, urgency and yield and makes the balance between cost, time and quality visible.	Completes the own tasks in the agreed order and reports it when two tasks clash with each other.	Chooses what is left undone when the planning is full, justifies this by importance and urgency and aligns it with those involved.	Sets the priority rules for the portfolio, stops running initiatives and accounts for the allocation of people and resources.
Time management and prioritising Allocates available time across tasks by urgency and importance, sets a sequence and adjusts it when new work arrives during the period.	Follows a task list provided by others and asks which task takes priority whenever new requests arrive.	Ranks own work by urgency and importance, builds in buffer time and explains to others why an item will arrive later.	Sets prioritisation agreements and planning standards across the organisation and decides which work streams receive time and capacity when both are scarce.
Managing workload pressure Keeps an overview when the volume of work rises, chooses what goes ahead and what does not, and puts the consequences to stakeholders.	Tells the supervisor that the work does not fit the available time and follows the choice that is made.	Cuts or shifts tasks independently when busy on the basis of importance, records this and discusses consequences with clients.	Redistributes work and capacity across departments in cases of structural overload and sets norms for sustainable workload distribution.
Working with digital devices and applications Uses computers, mobile devices and standard applications to carry out work tasks, adjusts settings and resolves simple usage problems without help.	Opens and uses the prescribed applications for own tasks and asks for help whenever an unfamiliar message appears.	Selects the appropriate device and application for each task and fixes common disruptions without support from others.	Defines organisation wide which digital workplace facilities are used and guides their introduction across all teams.
Operating machines Operates production machines, processing machines or transport equipment according to work instructions and intervenes when the process threatens to run outside set values.	Starts and stops a machine according to the work instruction and alerts the operator at any deviation.	Operates several machines independently, adjusts operating values to product condition and keeps output within the standard.	Determines how machines are operated across the organisation, draws up operating protocols and decides on replacing or modifying installations.

Skill	N1	N3	N5
Sustaining pace in repetitive work Maintains a constant pace and constant quality in recurring operations throughout the shift and spreads the effort over the available time.	Completes the assigned series of operations at the pace indicated and reports when a backlog arises.	Sustains the pace for a full shift, builds in own rhythm and short recovery moments and stays within the quality standard.	Sets attainable pace standards for the team and organises the work so that quality is retained at high output.
Clear oral expression Phrasing messages in spoken language so that the core point, the structure and the requested action are immediately clear to the listener.	Restates in own words what has been agreed and repeats the core of the instruction as a check.	Builds an unprepared spoken explanation into core point, background and next step, and adapts pace to the listener.	Sets the organisation wide standard for spoken clarity, explains complex strategic choices understandably and coaches others on their word choice.
Retaining and applying knowledge Keeps acquired professional knowledge available, retrieves the right rule or procedure at the moment it is needed and applies it correctly at work.	Looks up the required procedure in the manual and follows it step by step on a familiar task.	Knows the rules of the own field by heart and applies them without reference material in varying situations.	Oversees the knowledge base of the whole domain, decides which knowledge must be secured and documents it for the organisation.
Spreadsheets and worksheets Builds worksheets with formulas, references and pivot tables, checks outcomes and presents figures understandably in tables and charts.	Enters data in an existing worksheet and uses simple formulas such as sum and average as instructed.	Builds a worksheet with linked formulas and pivot tables, checks for errors and explains the calculation logic to colleagues.	Sets the standards for calculation models in the organisation and judges whether models are reliable enough for decision making.
Managing service levels and performance indicators Agrees measurable service and performance standards, measures the actual results and takes action when agreed levels are not met.	Reads the performance overview and reports which agreement was not met in the past week.	Draws up indicators and standards for a service, reports per period and carries out improvement actions on deviation.	Determines the system of service levels for the organisation and negotiates these with customers and suppliers.
Customs and international trade documentation Knows commodity codes, import duties and document requirements for cross border transport and prepares declarations and transport documents correctly.	Checks under guidance whether the required documents for a shipment are present and complete.	Independently determines commodity code and procedure for a shipment, files the declaration and answers questions from customs.	Sets up the organisation's customs processes, maintains the licences and accounts for compliance during inspections.

6 Assessment methods and validity

The validities are the corrected meta-analytic estimates from Sackett, Zhang, Berry and Lievens (2022) in the Journal of Applied Psychology, which replace the older Schmidt and Hunter (1998) figures. The spread matters as much as the mean: with a high SD, validity varies strongly by context.

Assessment method	rho	SD	What it is
Assessment center	0.29	0.09	Multiple exercises, multiple assessors, dimension-wise scoring.
Situational Judgement Test	0.12	0.11	Scenario with response options, scored on knowledge or behavioural tendency.
Werkproef	0.33	0.09	The candidate performs a representative work sample under standardised conditions.
Persoonlijkheidsvragenlijst	0.40	0.15	Self-report of behavioural preferences. At hrmforce the Big Fifty and the 15PF.
Certificaat/diploma	-	-	Formal proof of completed education or examination.
Praktijkobservatie	-	-	Structured workplace observation with a form based on behavioural anchors.
Structureerd interview	0.42	0.19	Behaviour-based interview with fixed questions and a rating scale per question.
Kennistoets	0.40	0.13	Test of declarative job knowledge, usually assembled per client.

7 Assessment instruments for this job

hrmforce instrument	Skills	What it measures
Werkproef	13	Representatief werkfragment onder gestandaardiseerde condities
Competency Check	11	Competentiebeoordeling op gedragsniveau
Kennistoets (klantspecifiek)	11	Toets van vakkennis, per klant samengesteld
360 Feedback	8	Meervoudige beoordeling op gedragsankers
Big Fifty	6	Persoonlijkheidsvragenlijst, 150 items, 25 factoren
15PF	1	Persoonlijkheidsprofiel, korter alternatief voor de Big Fifty
Pulse Survey	1	Periodieke meting op team- en organisatieniveau
Communicatiestijlen	1	Voorkeursstijl in communicatie

hrmforce instrument	Skills	What it measures
Ability Scan	1	Capaciteitentest: verbaal, numeriek en abstract redeneervermogen

8 How to use this profile

1. Agree the profile with the hiring manager before the first candidate is measured. Weights shifted afterwards make the outcome indefensible.
2. Choose the assessment method per skill from the Assessment method column. Combine at most three methods per candidate.
3. Calibrate the assessors in a two-hour session using the anchors in chapter 5. Anchors without rater training deliver little.
4. Fill in the match calculator and discuss the gaps in the development conversation. Type A and type G are selection criteria, not one-quarter development goals.

Source: hrmforce Skills Framework 2.0, version 2.0.0, built 2026-09-08. Crosswalks to ESCO v1.2.1, O*NET 31.0, Lightcast Open Skills, SFIA 9, DigComp 3.0, EntreComp, LifeComp, GreenComp, AILit, WEF Future of Jobs 2025, ISCO-08 and the Dutch CBS occupational classification BRC 2014 edition 2025. This profile is a starting point, not a standard: align it with your own organisation before selecting on it.